

Travel Diary

Mexico



*Route: Mexico City → Oaxaca → Tulum → Chichén Itzá → Campeche → Uxmal → Mérida →
Mexico City*

Fri January 20 – Mon February 6, 2023

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Day 1 – Friday, January 20 – Arrival: Frankfurt → Mexico City

Departure from Frankfurt: The holiday starts where it should: in the lounge, beer in hand. Almost twelve hours of flying ahead of us, plus seven hours of time difference – this is going to be a long day.





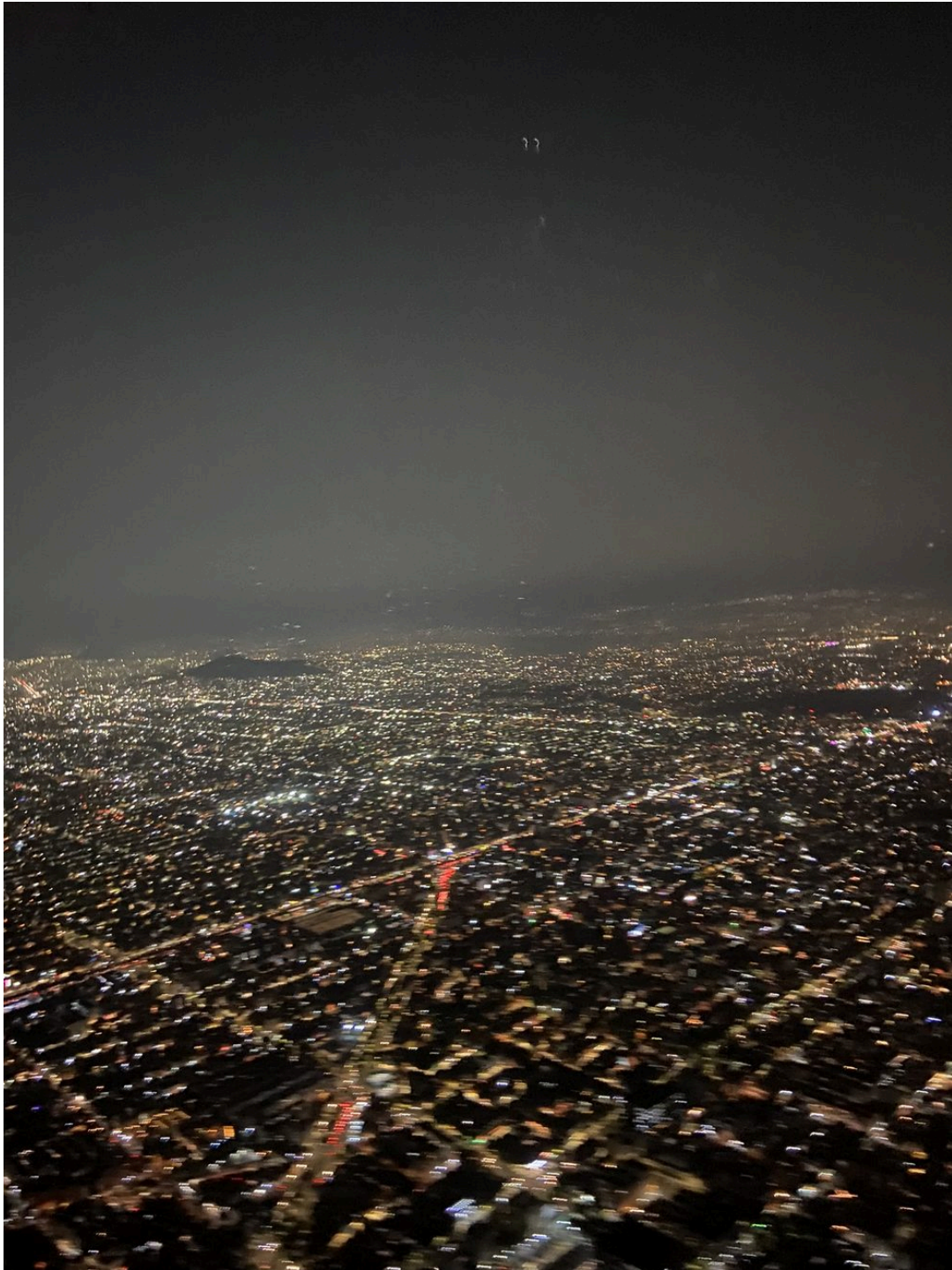
Good spirits on board before the jet lag kicks in.





Somewhere over the far north: snowfields and clouds as far as the eye can see.

Approach to Mexico City: On approach, the night-time sea of lights of one of the largest metro areas in the world – more than 20 million people at around 2,240 m in a former lake basin. The city sits on the bed of Lake Texcoco, where the Aztecs once founded Tenochtitlan.





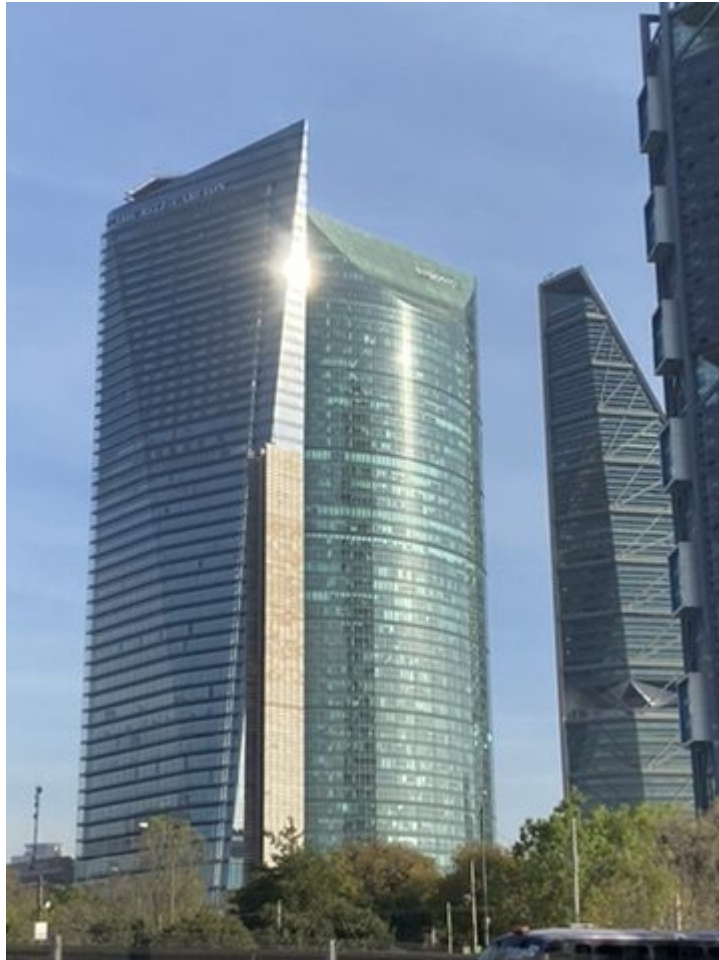
With our driver from the airport into town – first impression: traffic, even at this hour.

First evening: Drop the bags, head out for a first drink. Jet lag can wait.



Day 2 – Saturday, January 21 – Chapultepec, Polanco, Condesa & a Barbecue in Lomas

Morning walk along Avenida Chapultepec: Up early, on foot through Roma Norte towards Chapultepec. Street stands sell cut fruit in cups – mango, papaya, pineapple, with lime and Tajín (chili salt). Above it all rise the glass towers along Paseo de la Reforma.





Breakfast to go: fruit cups with chili and lime.



Tláloc monolith: In front of the National Museum of Anthropology stands the rain god Tláloc – a stone giant of around 168 tonnes. It was moved into the city from Coatlinchan in 1964; legend has it that a downpour broke out in the middle of the dry season when it arrived.



Polanco: market and breakfast: On Saturdays a tianguis (street market) sets up in Parque Lincoln in Polanco: mountains of limes, mangos and bananas. Then breakfast in a restaurant with a beautifully carved doorway – chilaquiles with a fried egg, the classic cure after a long night.







Condesa in the afternoon: Parque México is the green heart of Condesa – laid out on a former horse-racing track, which explains the oval shape of the neighbourhood (Hipódromo). The fountain with the water-jug bearer at Foro Lindbergh is a landmark of the park, surrounded by Art Deco houses and busy terraces.





Barbecue in Lomas: In the afternoon, an invitation to friends in Lomas: grill on, carne asada, a long table in the garden. Still the best way to get to know a city is at the table of its people.







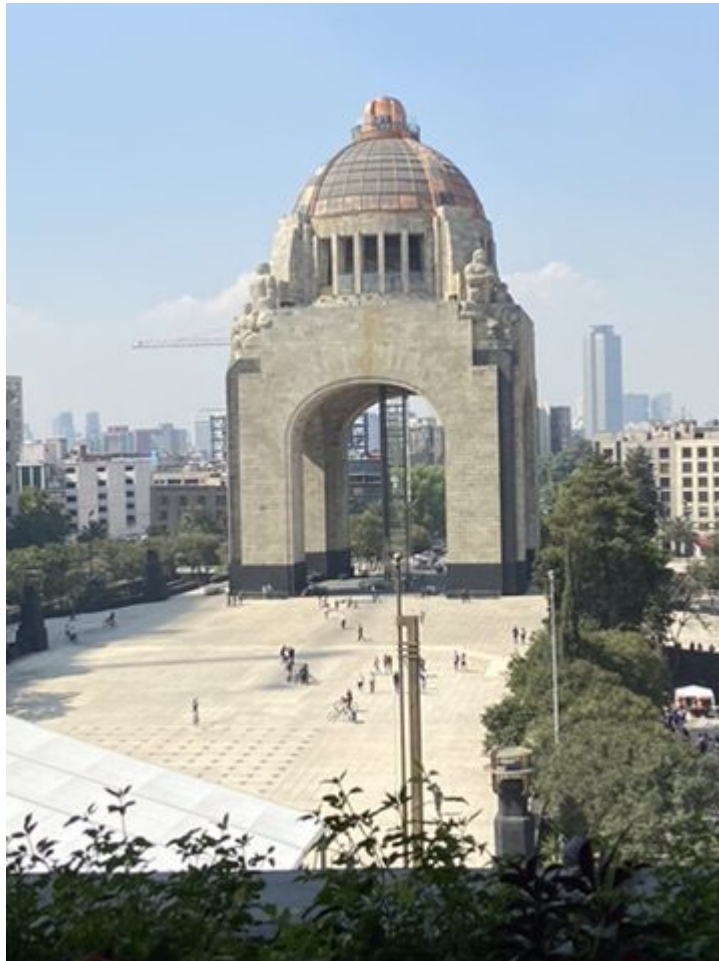




To finish, a bar in Roma Norte on Avenida Álvaro Obregón.

Day 3 – Sunday, January 22 – Centro Histórico: Revolución, Bellas Artes, Garibaldi

Monumento a la Revolución: Brunch on a rooftop terrace overlooking the Monument to the Revolution. It was originally planned as the dome of a gigantic legislative palace under Porfirio Díaz; the Revolution stopped the project and in 1938 the steel skeleton was turned into a monument. Its pillars now hold the remains of revolutionary heroes such as Madero, Carranza and Pancho Villa.







Sunday in the Alameda Central: The Alameda is the oldest public park in the Americas (1592). On Sundays it belongs to the people of the city: couples dance under the trees, folk dancers make their skirts fly.





Palacio de Bellas Artes: Art Nouveau marble façade, Art Deco interior: construction began in 1904 under Adamo Boari and was only finished in 1934, with a revolution and money problems in between. Inside hang murals by Rivera, Siqueiros and Orozco. The heavy building has been slowly sinking into the soft lakebed for decades.





Living statues in gold-painted charro costume – a photo for a few pesos.

Calle Madero and downtown: The pedestrian street Madero links Bellas Artes with the Zócalo and is packed on Sundays. A detour into the courtyard of a colonial palace, now full of restaurants under old trees.





Plaza Garibaldi: The beating heart of mariachi music, UNESCO intangible heritage since 2011. Musicians in charro suits wait on the square for customers and play song after song for a fee in the surrounding cantinas. Bronze statues honour the great voices of ranchera music.









And finally: lime into the bottle. Salud!

Day 4 – Monday, January 23 – Flight to Oaxaca

Heading south: Onward flight to Oaxaca, about an hour to the south-east. Below us Mexico City as far as the eye can see, framed by volcanic mountains.



Arrival in Oaxaca: The small airport lies in the valley between the mountains of the Sierra Madre del Sur. Pick up the rental car, load the bags, head to the historic centre. Oaxaca is considered Mexico's culinary capital – home of mole, mezcal and tlayudas.





First snack in Oaxaca.

Day 5 – Tuesday, January 24 – Monte Albán & Santo Domingo

Monte Albán: In the morning we leave town and drive up the mountain. Around 500 BC the Zapotecs began levelling the summit, some 400 m above the valley, to build their capital – the political centre of the Oaxaca Valley for over 1,000 years. The Gran Plaza is enormous, the 360° view over the three valleys even more so. A UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1987, together with Oaxaca's old town.





The "Danzantes": more than 300 stone slabs with contorted figures. Once read as dancers, today mostly interpreted as defeated, sacrificed captives.







In the site museum: Zapotec funerary urns, often showing deities such as the rain god Cocijó.



Evening: Santo Domingo: Back in town along the Macedonio Alcalá pedestrian street to the Templo de Santo Domingo. Plain and massive outside – built to withstand earthquakes – while inside the Baroque explodes: gilded altars, stucco up to the ceiling.







Dinner: Oaxacan cooking lives on corn, chili and patience: blue-corn tortillas, salsas freshly ground at the table in a molcajete (stone mortar).





Day 6 – Wednesday, January 25 – Oaxaca: Comida & Mezcal

Comida at a comedor: A quiet day in town. Comida, the main meal, is eaten in the early afternoon in Mexico – we end up in a simple family restaurant: quesadillas, milanesa, salsas in every degree of heat.





Mezcal: After the meal, the owner pours mezcal from a big bottle. Oaxaca produces most of Mexico's mezcal, mostly from the Espadín agave, whose hearts are roasted in earth pits – hence the smoky taste. Served with orange slices and sal de gusano, salt with ground agave worm and chili.











Tip: Mezcal is sipped, not shot: in small sips, ideally from a jícara or a small glass. The orange with sal de gusano comes afterwards.

Day 7 – Thursday, January 26 – Tacos, Mezcalería & the Zócalo at Night

Tacos: A late taquería: grilled meat topped with onion, coriander and a battery of salsas – from mild to "careful".









At the mezcalería: On to a mezcalería. Besides mezcal: regional craft beer and labels worth remembering.





The Zócalo at night: In the evening Oaxaca's centre becomes a stage: esquites stands, costumed performers, families. Protest tents stand on the Zócalo – plantones, used for decades by groups to make their demands visible. The cathedral and arcades are warmly lit.











Pop culture meets colonial backdrop: a "Predator" poses for kids' photos.



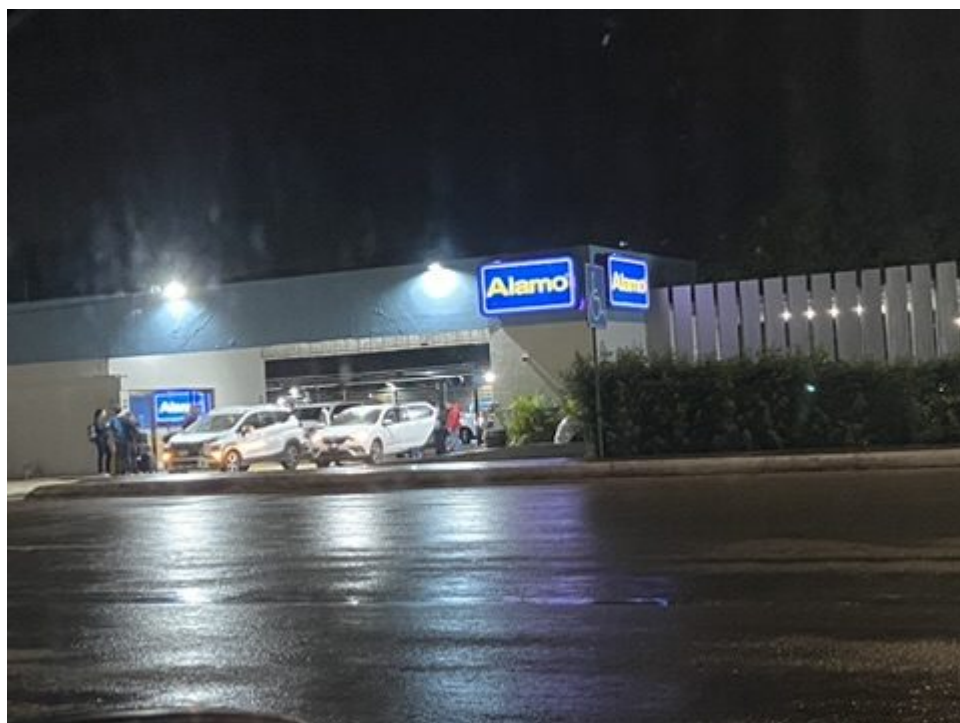


At night the pipas roll in: Oaxaca suffers from chronic water shortages and many homes are supplied by tanker truck.

Day 8 – Friday, January 27 – Oaxaca → Cancún → Tulum

Travel day to the Caribbean: Goodbye to the mountains: flight from Oaxaca to Cancún on the Yucatán Peninsula. In the evening we pick up the rental car and drive about 1.5 hours down the coast to Tulum.





Arrival in Tulum: Our place is in Aldea Zama, the new residential area between town and beach. After Oaxaca's colonial houses, this feels like a different country.



Day 9 – Saturday, January 28 – Tulum: Playa Paraíso & Beach Club

Playa Paraíso: White sand, turquoise water, palm trees – Playa Paraíso lies right next to the Maya ruins of Tulum and is considered one of the most beautiful beaches in Mexico. In January the weather is perfect: around 28 degrees, hardly any rain.











Beach club: The coast road to the south is lined with boutique hotels, restaurants and beach clubs. We end up in one of them – music, dancing, sunset. Tulum on a Saturday.

















Day 10 – Sunday, January 29 – Tulum: Taking a Breather

Day of rest: After Saturday, this is exactly what's needed: feet in the sea, later into the courtyard pool. No plans, no clock.







Day 11 – Monday, January 30 – Chichén Itzá & Arrival in Campeche

Setting off: Breakfast under a palm roof on colourful tablecloths, then across the peninsula into the interior.



Chichén Itzá: Mexico's best-known Maya site, at its peak around AD 900–1200, a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1988 and one of the "New Seven Wonders" since 2007. The Pyramid of Kukulcán (El Castillo) is a calendar in stone: 4×91 steps plus the platform make 365. At the equinoxes a band of shadow slithers down the staircase like a serpent. Climbing has been banned since 2008.



The Temple of the Warriors with the "Group of a Thousand Columns" in front – the columns once carried a roof.







Sacred Cenote and ball court: The Sacred Cenote was a well of sacrifice: in the early 20th century gold, jade, ceramics and human bones were recovered from its bottom. At 168 m the Great Ball Court is the largest in Mesoamerica; the wall reliefs show the beheading of a player.





Campeche: On to the Gulf coast and Campeche, in time for sunset on the Malecón. After repeated pirate raids the city was fortified from the late 17th century with a wall and bastions; its colourful old town has been a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1999.







Day 12 – Tuesday, January 31 – Campeche: Sea, Colours & Calle 59

Lunch by the sea: A slow day: lunch overlooking the Gulf, then a walk through the San Román neighbourhood. There's a classic car on every corner – including a vocho, the classic VW Beetle, which rolled off the line in Puebla until 2003.





Calle 59: In the evening Calle 59 turns into a pedestrian street with tables outside and string lights overhead. Papel picado, the punched tissue paper, even decorates the windows.



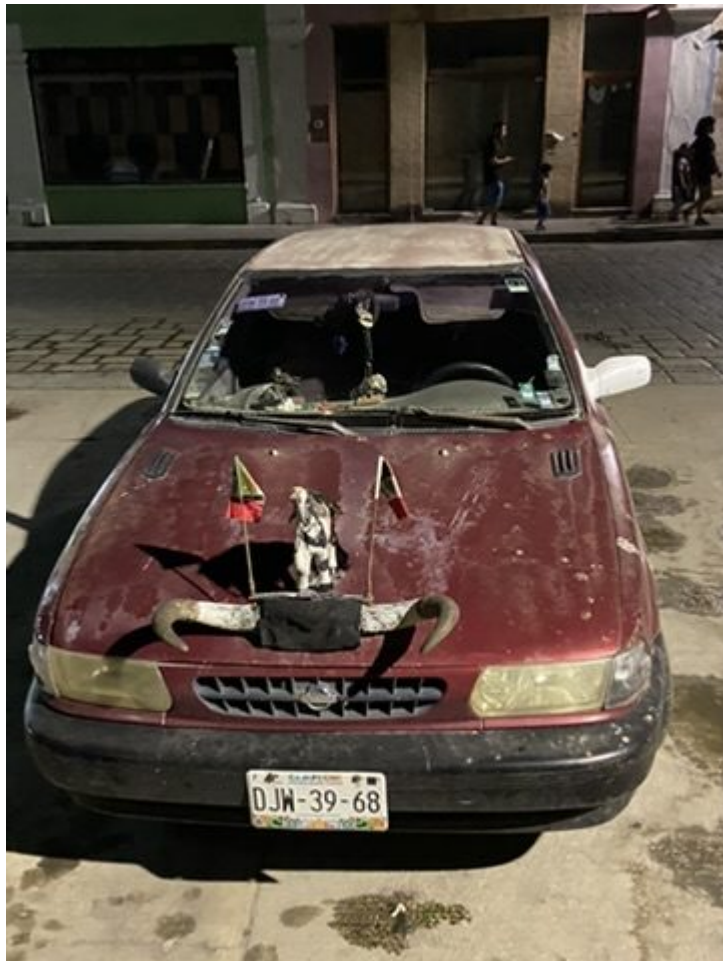




Colours of the flag.





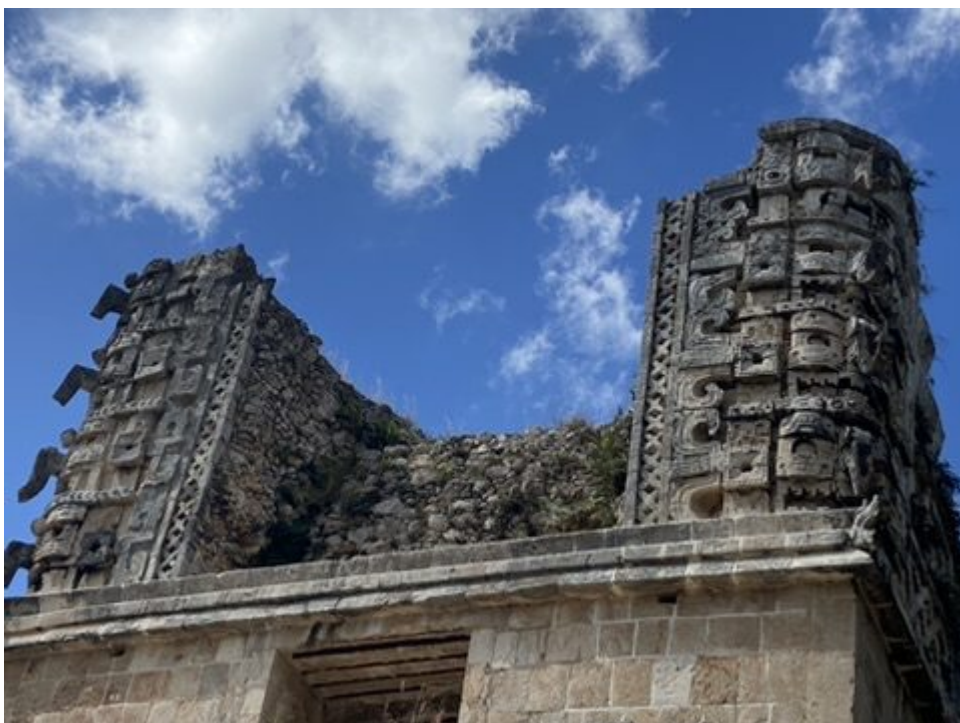


And to finish: probably the quirkiest car in Campeche.

Day 13 – Wednesday, February 1 – Uxmal, Mucuyché

Cenotes & Mérida

Uxmal: For many the most beautiful Maya site – and much quieter than Chichén Itzá. Uxmal is the masterpiece of the Puuc style: smooth lower walls topped by stone-mosaic friezes with lattice patterns and masks of the rain god Chaac. The Pyramid of the Magician has an oval base; legend says a dwarf built it in a single night. A UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1996.









The double-headed jaguar throne in front of the Governor's Palace.



Hacienda Mucuyché: On the way to Mérida: an old henequen hacienda. Sisal was made here from agave fibres, Yucatán's "green gold" around 1900. Today it draws visitors with two cenotes connected by a canal. One is named after Empress Carlota, who is said to have bathed here in 1865.







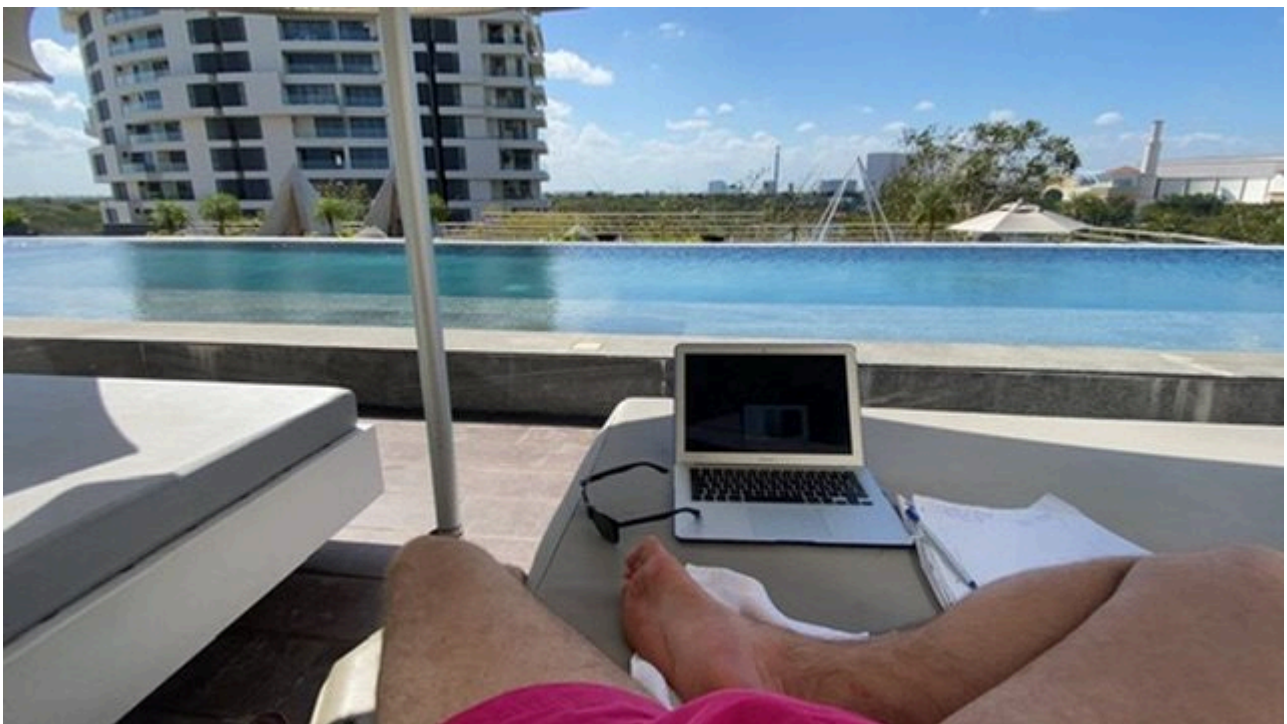
Arrival in Mérida: In the evening we reach Mérida, the "white city" and capital of Yucatán. Rooftop pool overlooking the city, then a drink in the old town.





Day 14 – Thursday, February 2 – Mérida: Pool & Pause

Pause in Mérida: A day without plans: lounge by the pool, a bit of laptop time, sitting together in the evening. Exactly right after two weeks on the road.







Day 15 – Friday, February 3 – Back to Mexico City

Back to the capital: Return the car, fly back to the capital – this time into the new Felipe Ángeles Airport (AIFA), opened in 2022 on a military base about 45 km north of the city. On the wall, an illustrated map of the peninsula we just left behind.





Evening in Condesa: Back in our neighbourhood: craft beer at a little stand, then dinner with salsas and Mexican home cooking.







Day 16 – Saturday, February 4 – Xochimilco

Xochimilco: The canals of Xochimilco are the last remnant of the lake system the Aztecs lived on. Between them lie chinampas, artificially built-up "floating gardens", a farming method more than 1,000 years old – UNESCO World Heritage since 1987. You rent a trajinera, a brightly painted flat boat that a boatman punts through the canals with a long pole.







Essential on board: a michelada.









Floating vendors: snacks, flowers, blankets and entire mariachi bands pull up alongside by boat.







Surprise: pelicans. American white pelicans spend the winter in Xochimilco.



Dinner: Back in town: dinner at a restaurant in Hipódromo, modern Mexican cuisine on the plate.



Day 17 – Sunday, February 5 – Chapultepec, Anthropology Museum & Farewell

Bosque de Chapultepec: Last full day. At around 680 hectares, Chapultepec Park is one of the largest urban parks in Latin America. At the entrance stands the monument to the Niños Héroes: six young cadets who died in 1847 defending Chapultepec Castle against US troops.





Museo Nacional de Antropología: Mexico's most important museum, built in 1964 by Pedro Ramírez Vázquez. In the courtyard a single column carries the huge roof "El Paraguas", from which water rains down. More than 20 halls: from the Olmecs to the Aztecs, plus the living indigenous cultures of today.





Árbol de la vida: ceramic tree of life, typical of Metepec.







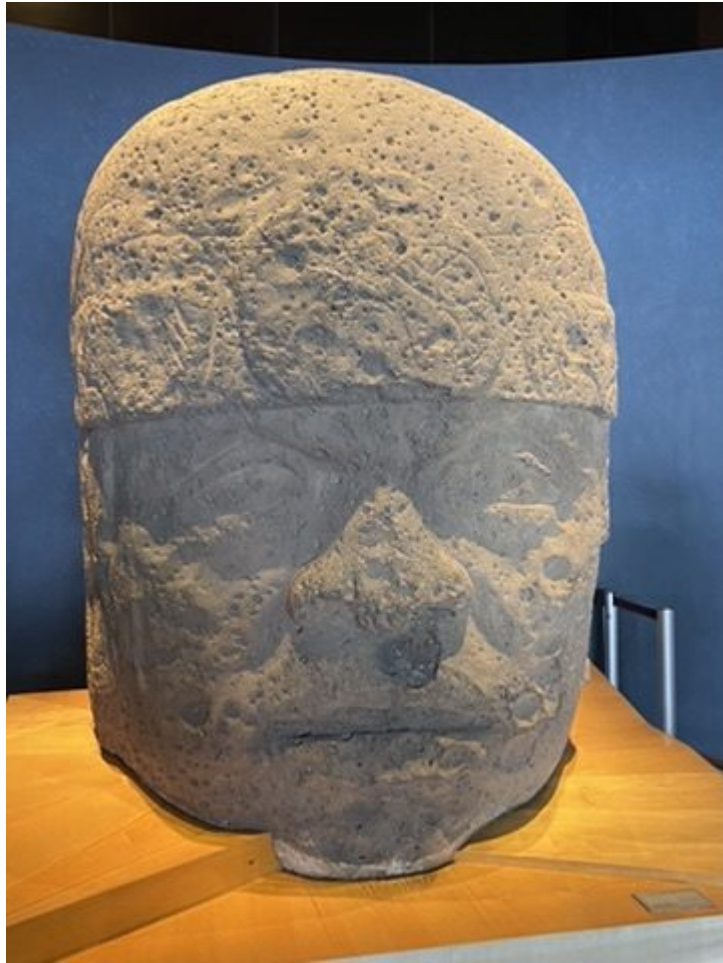
The Sun Stone: 24 tonnes of basalt, 3.6 m across, unearthed at the Zócalo in 1790 – the museum's most famous piece.



Diorama of the Tlatelolco market, which the Spanish conquistadors described as larger than any market in Europe.



Coatlicue, mother of the gods, with a skirt of serpents.



Olmec colossal head – around 3,000 years old.







As a farewell, concheros dance in feathered headdresses outside the museum – a tradition that lives on.

Farewell: The next morning, Monday, February 6, it's off to the airport early and back to Frankfurt. Seventeen days between the capital, the mountains, the Caribbean and the Gulf coast, three Maya cities – and a long list of places we have to come back for.
